Kindling

By Cathleen Sakamai

CHILD: **(Pg 15-21)** *(pointing)* ***Look at that girl's face, Mommy. What's wrong with her?***

SHE is a woman in her late twenties to early thirties. She appears normally dressed, casual and calm. SHE addresses the audience directly.

SHE: I want to say *(beat)*, ***I don't know, sweetheart. I don't know what's wrong with me.*** We walk around with our histories bolted to us like suicide bombs, like they could detonate in an hour or tomorrow . . . Or right now. You know what I mean, right? Do you ever feel like that?

INTRODUCTION

Children depend on their parents to protect them and keep them safe. But unfortunately, this is not always the case. According to the National Children's Alliance: ***More than 600,000 children are abused in the U.S each year.***** But the ramifications don't stop when a child is rescued from an abusive situation. While bruises, cuts, and broken limbs will eventually heal, emotional trauma takes a lifetime to overcome.*

If only you could un-read those pages in your life's book, or if there was a way to erase the images and flashbacks that come to your mind. Sadly, these traumas are burned into the very fiber of your being and sometimes scars never heal.

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SHE: She gave me an assignment. My therapist, that is. She said that I should write all of it down. And the **"it"**, of course, was everything that troubled me. She told me to *start small.* Irritations, right? But there's so much that's irritating. And the more I started to think about what was irritating, the more irritated I started to feel about it, and then I started to feel like some kind of self-pitying freak, which I'm not, and . . . Okay. I'll just give you a couple off the list:

I'm irritated when I'm running late for work and the line at Starbucks is longer than usual, and I'm waiting and there's eight people in front of me, and it gets to the last

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person in front of me and she's gets up there to the register and she . . . she just stares up at the menu board thing like it's the first time she's ever seen it . . . and I think, "what have you been thinking about for the last ten minutes while we we're all standing here waiting?" She's standing there, it's like she's deliberating over a major life decision. I mean, I don't make this stuff up. And it makes me feel unkind, which I'm not, or I hope that I'm not at least, and . . .

Well, this sort of goes into this same one on the list, but let's say this same woman, right, this woman who takes fourteen minutes to decide on a tall mocha, she catches my eye as she leaves the register, and no matter how intensely irritated I am, I smile, because I always try to, and . . . well, she just looks away.

I'm not a violent person. Honestly. I catch spiders in water glasses in my kitchen and take them out to the backyard. But sometimes, I just want to slap people. Make them feel ***something***, right? You smile at someone, some random stranger at the grocery store, or waiting at a light, or passing on the sidewalk, and they either just gaze back or look away. And I think, it just takes a millisecond. Just a blink, right? That's all it takes to move the muscles of your mouth to smile back. And people -- a lot of people -- they just can't be bothered to do that. But I try to make that effort. When people look at me. When they do. I don't want to lose that kindness.

So, I'm making my list, my canon of vexing issues, so to speak, and the list is growing longer and longer, and I'm realizing that all of these things, these terrible irritants are about other people. And that worries me, I guess. I start to think about what other people might put on their lists.

Would you put the leaky faucet in your guest bathroom on your list? I bet you would. But I didn't. Would you put your bills, how much you owe on your student loans on your list? I have an idea that you would. I didn't. And I owe a lot of money on my student loan. I just put people. And I started thinking, I guess, about my kindness.

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And I started thinking about Matthew.

Matthew. Never Matt. Always Matthew. I never asked him why.

We dated for almost a year. And, yes, he treated me well. He was respectful and kind and we laughed together and had shared interests and all those things that are supposed to *make it work,* right? But I treated him well too. I want you to understand that. I did. And then, about a month ago, we're sitting down on the sofa, and he's poured me a glass of wine -- and something about this is feeling terribly staged -- and I'm thinking, this is *it,* he's going to propose to me.

But that wasn't *it* at all. What he does propose is that I explain to him. *Explain.* And this man who I believed was patient, and was kind, he's suddenly using words like *distant* and *aloof,* and I'm thinking, very quickly now, that, no, that's not it at all, I'm funny and charming, but I don't say these things to him, instead I go hot and I know that I'm just boiling over and I'm screaming at him, I'm screaming that *I'm not ready* and that he doesn't *deserve an explanation.* I scream at him, and I say awful things. I tell him that I don't have to explain.

And Matthew is very quiet. And he says, ***"You're right. You don't."***

And I awoke the next morning to a grey sky, my throat tired from the tears and the yelling, and I was alone. Matthew had taken his things and left a note on the bedside table. And I screamed as loud as I could because I wanted to fill the whole house up with my words. And there was no one there to scream or whisper back.

And that was irritating. I was irritated. But I would still smile at you on the street. You betcha. I would.

We walk around with our histories bolted to us like suicide bombs, like they could detonate in an hour or tomorrow . . . Or right now. You know what I mean, right? Do you ever feel like that? It's like that bomb detonated when I was thirteen-years-old and the shrapnel landed and grew up around itself. A bizarre garden. A wasteland.

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I do not want to explain these things. I want to forget them. But my therapist, with her kind eyes, her gentle tone, she tells me that I can unlock these rooms, that I can allow some space. She asks me about being thirteen. And I hate this. It feels like I'm being pushed under water and I'm kicking and fighting to come up for air. My lungs are full. I'm breaking apart. Detonated.

I'm thirteen. The gangplank between girl and not-quite, right? My mother remarried when I was little, my father was gone, non-existent, whatever. But my mother's husband, my step-father, Nicholas, he had always been there. And my mother, I mean, she drank and she was difficult, but Nicholas, he was always there. My track meets, school plays, whatever. Nick was there. I loved him so much.

I'm thirteen. My mother sits me down, she's been drinking, and she tells me that ***she knows*** what's been going on between Nicholas and I. That I'm getting older and that he's been coming in to see me at night and that I'm a woman now, and that I wanted ***it***. And I try to answer and she hits me across the face until I'm bleeding and I can't get away from her . . . she was not kind. *(SHE gestures to her face.)*

You're wondering if it's related? There's usually an explanation. Two nights later, I awoke to my bedroom filled with flames. I couldn't get out. Like kindling thrown to the flames. They had to come in to get me. She started the fire in my bedroom. About 60% percent of my body was covered in third degree bums. The worst were on my face.

Little children in grocery stores say, ***Look at that girl's face, Mommy. What's wrong with her?*** And I want to say back to them, ***I don't know, sweetheart. I don't know what's wrong with me.***

Sometimes scars don't heal. We carry around so much baggage. It breaks our backs to heave it around with us. Sometimes I just want someone to smile back. You might if you knew. You might if you looked like this.

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It practically makes me physically sick to say it, but Nicholas never touched me. Never so much as looked at me wrong. I miss him terribly. I do.

I look in mirrors sometimes and imagine how I might have looked . . . Are you ever grateful for being normal? I think, more than anything, that's what irritates me. I just want to be normal. I just want the kindness ***here*** *(gestures to her smile)* to be ***here*** *(gestures to her heart)* too. I don't think that's a lot to ask.

When I smile at you, I want you to smile back. It's like being invisible. ***I just want you to see me. I want you to look at me, I want you to make eye contact with me, and see me.***

That's what I wanted from Matthew, but I didn't know how to ask. The note he left on my bedside table was simple:

I want to know you, but you have to let me.

When there's room in your heart for me, please call me. Ill be waiting.

Love, Matthew

I'm trying. I'm trying so hard. I want to love and be loved. I want to be seen.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier
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**** Source of introduction statistic***
https://www.nationalchildrensalliance.org/media-room/national-statistics-on-child-abuse/

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